

How Political Bias Shapes Public Perception in Major News Networks



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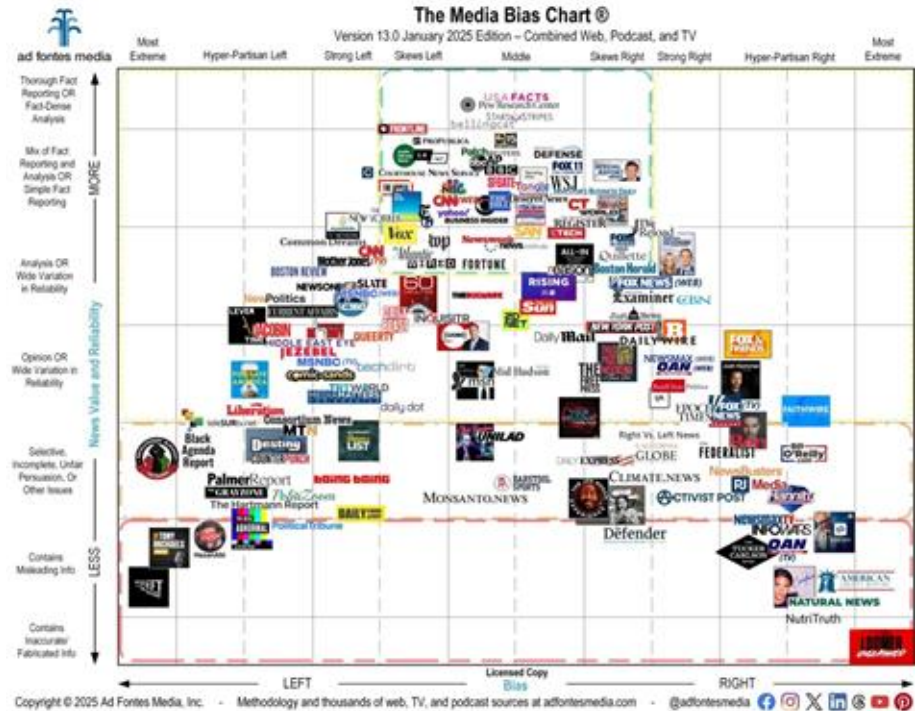
Why We Chose This Topic

- News influences everyday thinking and political beliefs
- Major networks present themselves as neutral, but each has political tendencies
- People who rely on a single source only hear one curated version of reality
- Understanding bias explains why people interpret the same events differently



Thesis Statement

Major news networks shape public opinion through political bias; using framing, agenda-setting, selective coverage, and tone to influence how people interpret current events.



Framing Theory

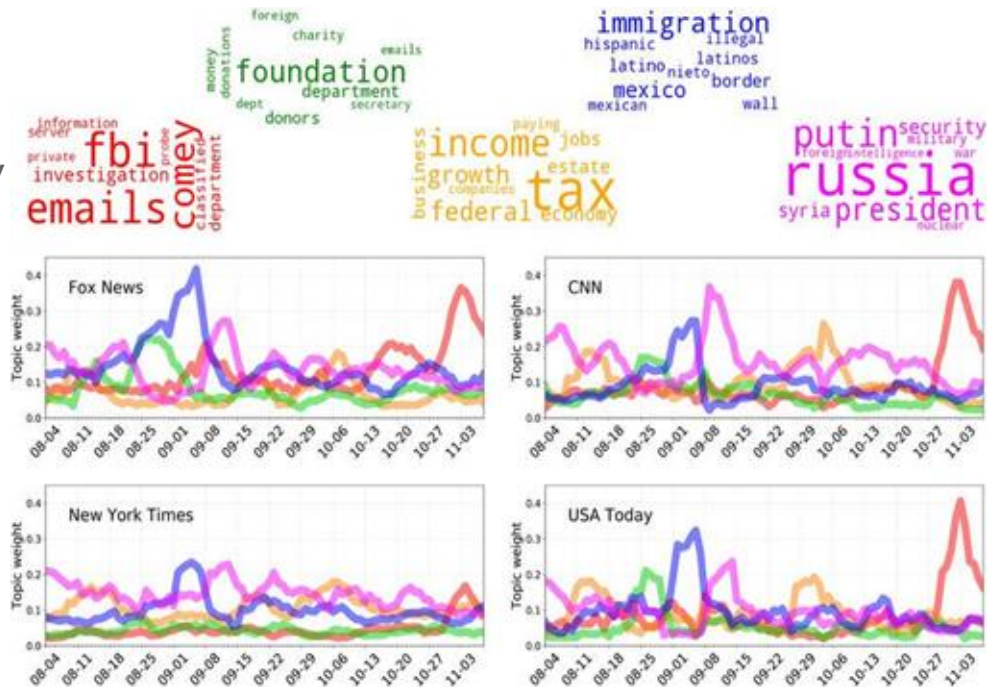
- News does more than report facts
- Networks choose how events are presented
- Emphasize certain details while downplaying others
- Tone and wording guide audience interpretation

Quote: “Framing guides the audience toward certain conclusions without explicitly stating them” (Pew Research Center 2020)



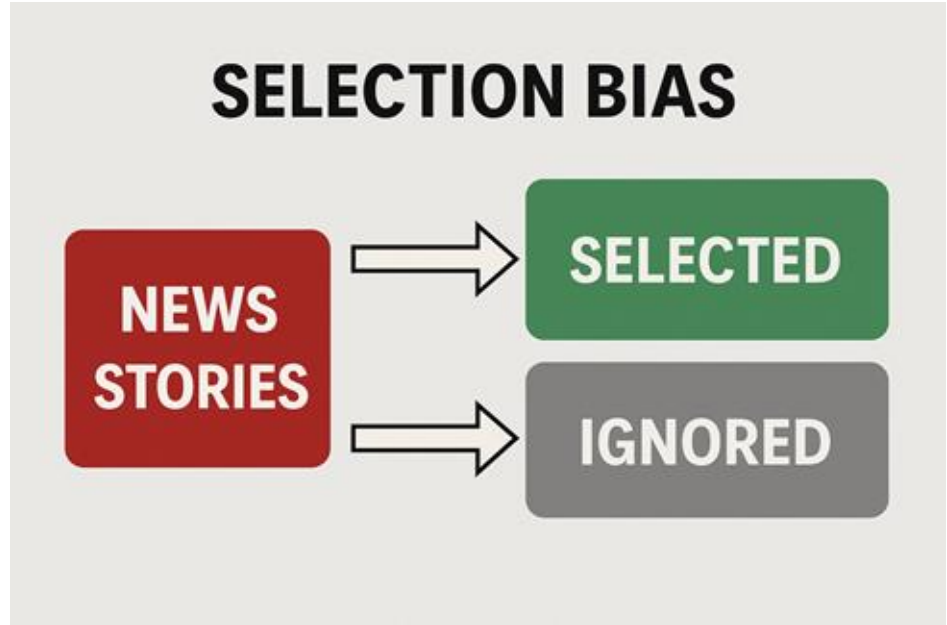
Agenda Setting

- Determines what audiences see as important
- Networks cover some topics heavily while minimizing others
- What gets repeated feels urgent
- What gets ignored feels unimportant
- Influences public priorities



Selection Bias

- Bias begins with the decision of what to cover
- Networks choose what events to highlight or exclude
- Creates different “realities” depending on the outlet
- Algorithms amplify extreme or emotional stories



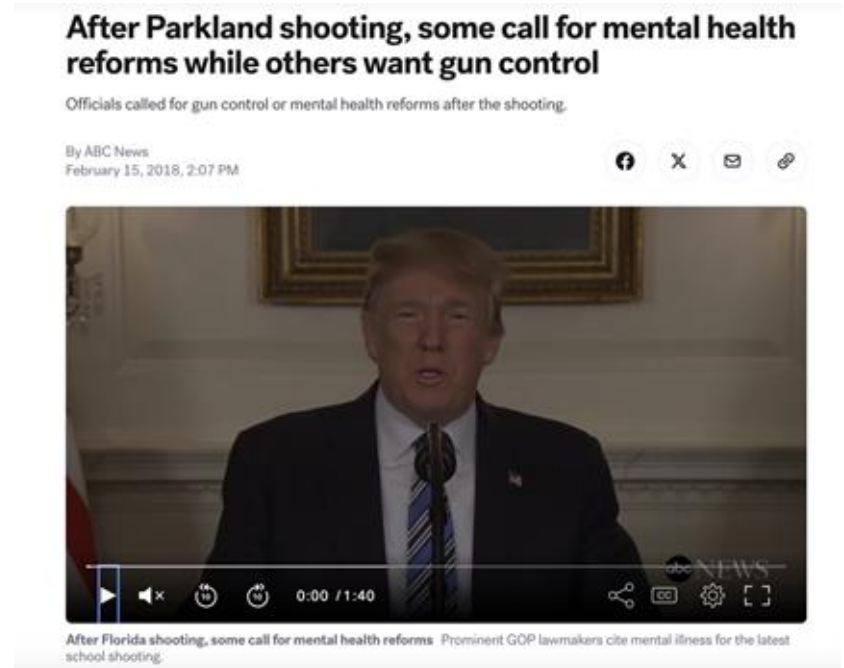
Framing Example #1: Parkland School Shooting

Left-Leaning Outlets:

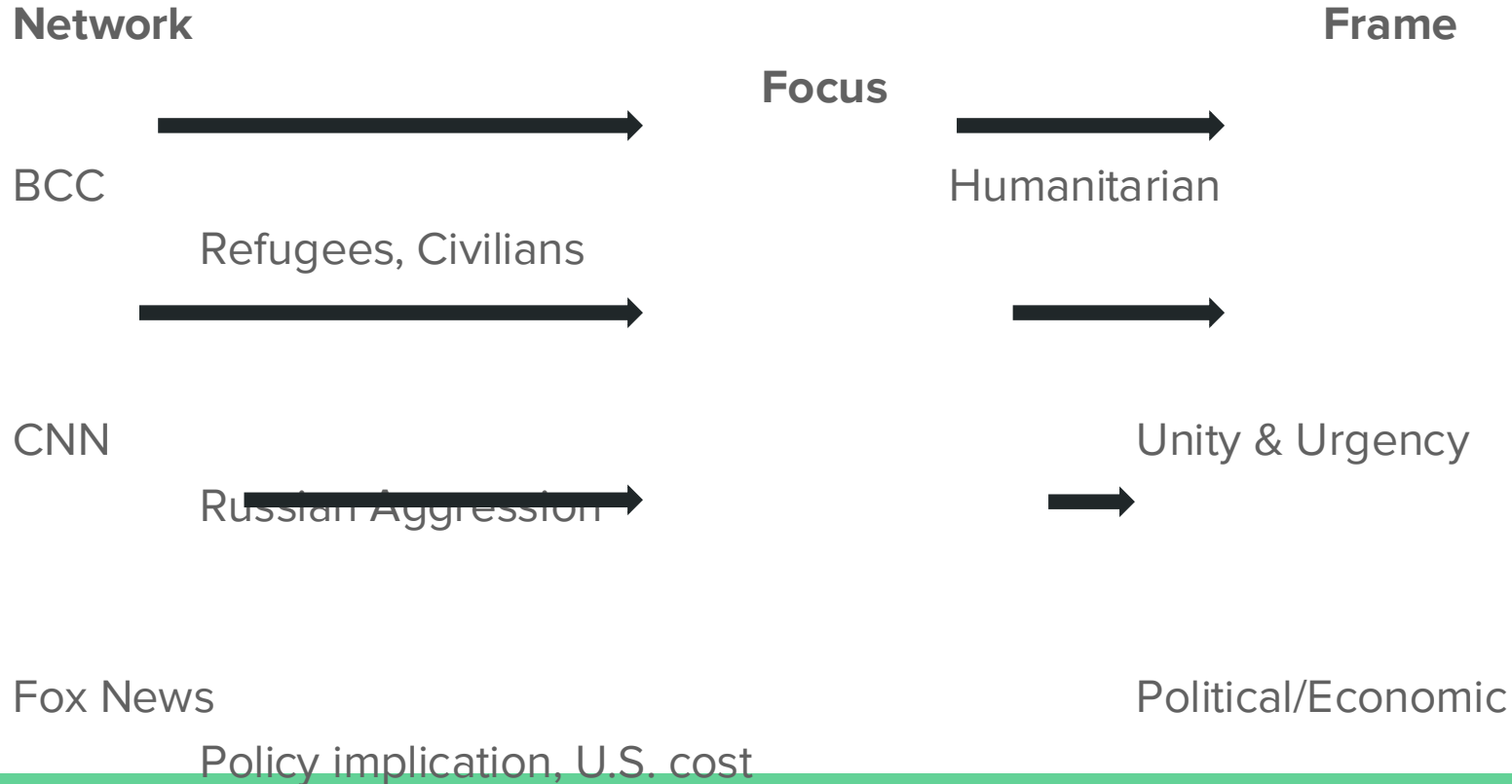
- Emphasized activism, youth leadership, gun control

Right-Leaning Outlets:

- Emphasized mental health, personal responsibility, school security



Framing Example #2: Ukraine War Coverage



Outrage Journalism

- Emotional content attracts engagement
- News increasingly uses conflict, anger, danger
- Sensational coverage drives views
- Bias becomes structural, not just ideological

OUTRAGE JOURNALISM



Real-World Consequences

Political bias shapes:

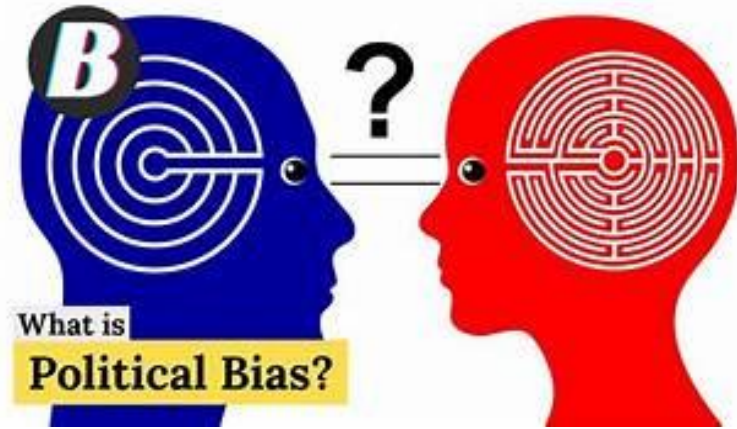
- Public opinions and beliefs
- Voting priorities
- Interpretation of events
- Polarization and division
- Trust in institutions

These all lead to an even more polarizing nation.



What Should We Do as Consumers

- Watch for framing
- Use more than one news source
- Check the source
- Compare how different networks cover the same story
- Question everything



Conclusions

- Major networks filter reality through framing and agenda-setting
- Bias influences what people think is important
- Media bias fuels polarization
- Recognizing bias improves critical thinking
- Relying on multiple sources helps avoid narrow viewpoints

